India’s Tiruvila

R. Sudha

From the very first step we took in Kanyakumari, Tamil Nadu, the atmosphere crackled with energy. But that’s how it is in any political rally or campaign. This is perhaps why many people viewed the Bharat Jodo Yatra as a one-off political event. But were they mistaken! The Yatra slowly burgeoned into a movement—a huge tiruviḻā (festival) that declared in every inch it crossed that we the people were the architects of our destiny.

The Yatra around Rahul Gandhi was very different from what it was for the rest of us. The security concerns, the walking interactions, the periodic involvement of senior leaders, the bystanders whom Rahul ji called in and hugged, the many emotions that he shared and felt, all in full view of the media glare, gave the first 2 kilometres of the Yatra a very different flavour. But the 8 or 10 kilometres after that were an entirely different experience. For each of us, it was a varied experience. In that sense it was many different yatras flowing out of and into one big yatra.

For me, with every hand I shook and every greeting I exchanged, I sensed the heartbeat of my fellow countrymen. Many cheered us on, carrying their party flags and badges. At that time I was so swept up in the initial tempo and excitement that I waved enthusiastically and shook their hands. But later I began wondering why they were there. I first thought the worst—maybe people had come just to see India’s biggest political celebrity, Rahul Gandhi. Maybe they had come to check how strong the Congress party was. Or maybe they had come to witness a huge spectacle, like all of us do. These thoughts began worrying me and I began asking people as often as I could. And I was very taken aback. The majority of